



These layered rice fields in the Mu Cang Chai district of northeastern Vietnam were carved out of the mountainsides hundreds of years ago. With simple hand tools, early farmers labored to make use of every scrap of fertile land. Today, the terraces produce much of the country's rice. Covering about 4,900 acres (2,000 hectares), the plants change color from

green to gold with the seasons. Growing rice is still hard work, even today. It is difficult to use machinery on such a steep incline so work is done by hand. After planting, farmers are constantly weeding, and in the run up to harvest, the terraces are kept flooded with stream water carried by farmers down the mountains in bamboo pipes.